

"If the theme is simple, you can include a hundred details that create the illusion of actuality better."

UNIVERSAL EYE

A complete filmmaker, with mastery over every aspect, he was ruthless in his quest for cinematic perfection. Yet, even working round the clock, he never compromised on a life fully lived.

■ By Sandip Ray

Even as a child, I realised that our home was different. This was after the success of *Pather Panchali* in 1955, when interesting personalities from around the world would come to meet my father. On the day it was released, my mother, Bijoya Ray, watched the film in the theatre with me, all of two years, in her lap. During the interval, however, she realised that I didn't like the dark auditorium, and

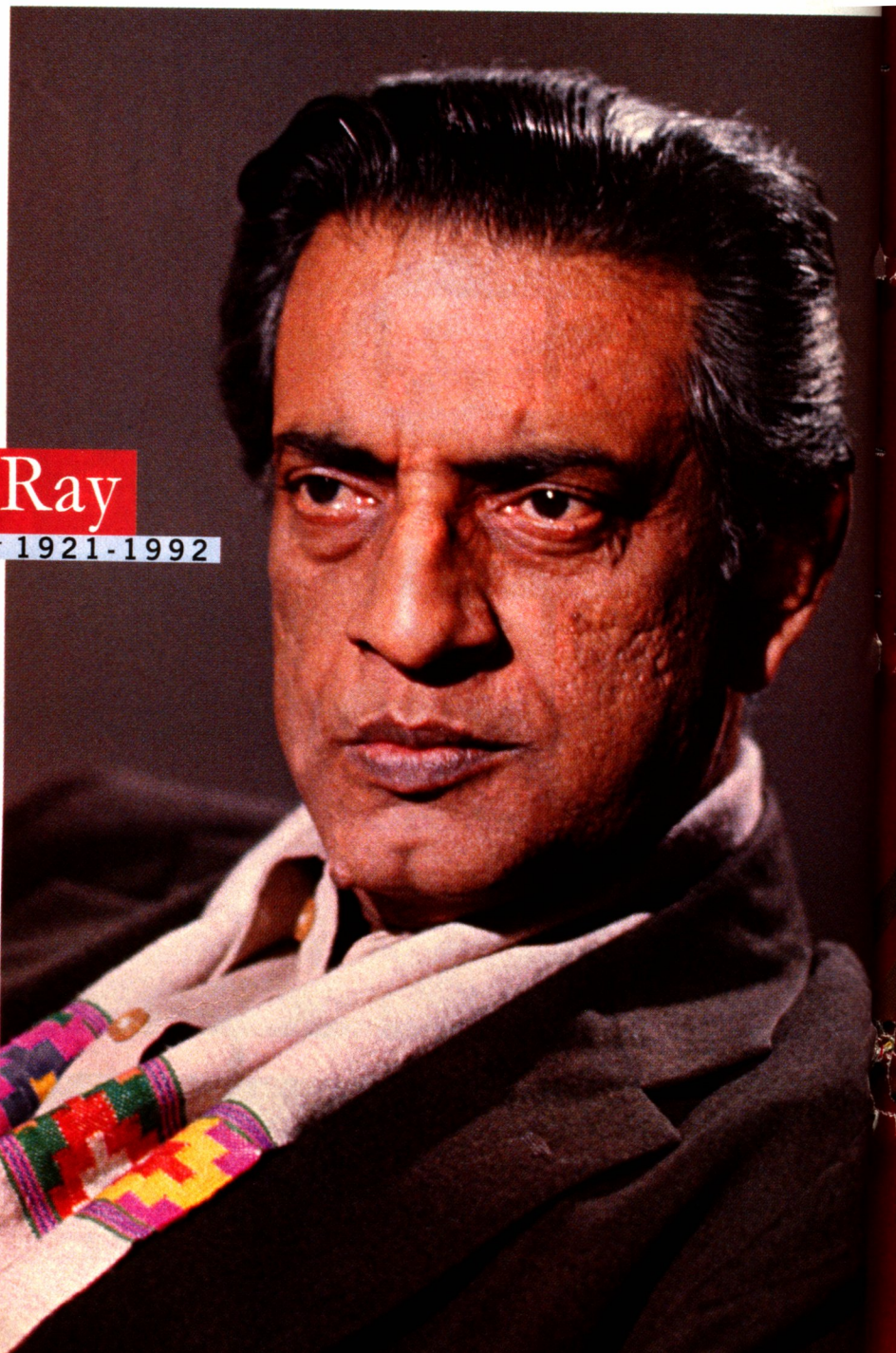
Satyajit Ray

Filmmaker 1921-1992

decided to bring me home. She says that after we returned, I insisted on going back and seeing it through. That was the power of movies, which enthralled my subconscious even at that young age. Baba's film was the best way to be initiated into it.

My father gave his family a lot of time. He would almost always schedule outdoor shoots during my summer or winter vacations so we could all go. In those days, actors were a lot less busy, so such shoots could be easily arranged. That's how I was present through so many of his films. And that's how I understood what great filmmaking was all about.

He worked round the clock. He would wake up at an unearthly hour, before anyone else at home stirred and had a set morning routine. After breakfast, he would spend the entire morning replying to letters. He never



CORBIS